

POV: You Still Live With Your Parents at 30

— *While Everyone Else Pays Someone Else's Mortgage*

231

SHOTS

11

STAGES

~24 min

RUNTIME

~6s

PER SHOT

Flat 2D cartoon webcomic style · ARC format · Narration at 2.7 words/sec

Every prompt is standalone: copy one paragraph, paste it into your image generator, done.

How to use this book

Work one stage at a time. Each **shot** is one image on screen for about 6 seconds of narration. The timecode shows where it lands in the voiceover, so you can drop images straight onto your editing timeline.

- 1. Copy the **Image Prompt** paragraph and paste it into your image generator. It already contains the style, the character descriptions, the camera, the lighting and the mood.
- 2. Check that the protagonist matches the reference below. If your tool drifts, attach one approved protagonist image as a reference.
- 3. Tick the boxes on the card as you go: Image ✓, Animated ✓, Placed ✓.
- 4. In the edit, add a slow push-in or pan to every image so the 6 seconds feel alive.

Locked visual style

flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail.

Protagonist

A young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan. He is always the darkest value in the frame.

STAGES	OUTFIT	LIGHTING
1 & 10 · Rooftop (age 30)	Charcoal quarter-zip	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline
2-4 · Ages 22-24	Plain charcoal hoodie, younger and thinner	flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones
5-7 · Ages 25-27	Charcoal crewneck sweater	soft clean daylight, neutral tones
8-9 · Ages 28-29	Charcoal quarter-zip	soft warm daylight, gentle shadows
11 · Moving out	Charcoal quarter-zip	warm natural light with amber accents
Bedroom at night	Any	dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

Cast reference

These descriptions are already built into every prompt they appear in. Keep each character looking the same across all shots.

Marcus	Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt.
Theo	Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt.
Jenna	Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan.
Priya	Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket.
Mother	His mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan.
Father	His father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt.
Alana	Alana is a lively woman with curly black hair and a rust-colored sweater.
Greg	Greg is a friendly balding middle-aged manager in a tucked-in navy polo.
Aunt Denise	Aunt Denise is a heavyset woman in her sixties with teased hair and a bold red blouse.
Cousin Kyle	Cousin Kyle is a broad young man in a trucker cap and a team jersey.
Uncle	His uncle is a loud gray-haired man in a sweater vest.
Leasing agent	The leasing agent is a polished young woman in a fitted gray blazer.
Mechanic	The mechanic is an older man in blue coveralls with grease-stained knuckles.
Loan officer	The loan officer is a middle-aged man in a navy suit and striped tie.

Recurring visual motifs

31 glow-in-the-dark plastic stars on the bedroom ceiling · the spare key on a faded blue high-school lanyard · the \$800 envelopes on the kitchen table · the circled “22 payments left” · the porch light · the heated rooftop pool · Theo and Jenna’s red front door · Marcus’s linen shirt and watch

Stage overview

Tick off each stage when all of its shots are generated.

STAGE	TITLE	SHOTS	TIME	DONE
1	The Rooftop Age 30 · The secret in his pocket	1-22 22 shots	00:00-02:17	☐
2	The Driveway and the Rule Age 22 · Four boxes and one decision	23-45 23 shots	02:17-04:43	☐
3	"So When Are You Moving Out?" Age 22-23 · The question that never stops	46-64 19 shots	04:43-06:47	☐
4	The Invisible Years Age 23-24 · Everyone else's life, in pictures	65-88 24 shots	06:47-09:16	☐
5	The Loft and the Mortgage Age 25 · The pen, the envelope, the \$800	89-115 27 shots	09:16-12:07	☐
6	The Crash Age 26 · When fear doesn't get a vote	116-138 23 shots	12:07-14:34	☐
7	The Reversal Age 27 · Lives that have to be fed	139-154 16 shots	14:34-16:14	☐
8	The Nine Seconds Age 28 · What the rent money really bought	155-172 18 shots	16:14-17:58	☐
9	The Cost of Silence Age 29 · When the secret becomes a wall	173-193 21 shots	17:58-20:11	☐
10	Back on the Rooftop Age 30 · Paid in full	194-214 21 shots	20:11-22:24	☐
11	Moving Out After · The last star	215-231 17 shots	22:24-24:06	☐

STAGE 1 OF 11

The Rooftop

Age 30 · The secret in his pocket

Shots 1-22 · 22 images
00:00 – 02:17

001

SHOT

00:00

4.8s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“It’s 7:40 on a Saturday night and you’re standing on a rooftop downtown,”

IMAGE PROMPT

Wide view of a downtown rooftop party at night, the protagonist standing near the railing holding a cocktail glass, guests mingling, string lights overhead, a glowing heated pool behind. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide establishing shot, protagonist off-center left. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: stylish, quietly detached.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide establishing shot, protagonist off-center left	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	stylish, quietly detached	holding his drink, observing the party

002

SHOT

00:04

4.8s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“holding a drink you didn’t pay for. It’s Marcus’s thirtieth birthday. His building.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist holding a fancy cocktail he didn’t buy, a "Happy 30th Marcus" gold balloon banner strung behind him, Marcus laughing with guests in the background. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: celebratory, ironic.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	celebratory, ironic	glancing at the banner

003

SHOT

00:09

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“His roof. His heated pool glowing blue behind everyone's heads. Your phone buzzes in your pocket. You don't need to look.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the protagonist's jacket pocket with a phone vibrating inside, small motion lines around it, his hand hanging still beside it. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: secretive, tense.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

secretive, tense

ACTION

the phone buzzing in the pocket

004

SHOT

00:17

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You already know what it says. One line. A balance. Two words after it. Paid in full.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A ghostly overlay of a phone notification floating beside the protagonist reading "Paid in full", blurred so the details stay hidden. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up with overlay. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: mysterious.

CAMERA

close-up with overlay

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

mysterious

ACTION

the notification hovering faintly

005

SHOT

00:23

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You keep it in your pocket. There are five of you up here. The same five since sophomore year.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Five friends standing together at the rooftop railing: the protagonist, Marcus, Theo, Jenna and Priya, the city skyline behind them. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt; Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan; Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide group shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: familiar, nostalgic.

CAMERA

medium-wide group shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

familiar, nostalgic

ACTION

the friends clinking glasses

006

SHOT

00:30

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Marcus in a linen shirt with the tags still on the inside collar.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus in a crisp linen shirt with a visible price tag still peeking out of the inside collar, holding a cocktail and grinning. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up on Marcus. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: flashy, careless.

CAMERA

medium close-up on
Marcus

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the
blue glow of a heated pool against
a cool night city skyline

MOOD

flashy, careless

ACTION

adjusting his collar
without noticing the tag

007

SHOT

00:35

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Theo and Jenna holding hands, a little tired, a little proud, the way people look when they own a house.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo and Jenna holding hands at the party, both looking tired but proud, house keys on a ribbon clipped to Jenna's bag. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: settled, weary pride.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the
blue glow of a heated pool against
a cool night city skyline

MOOD

settled, weary
pride

ACTION

leaning into each other

008

SHOT

00:42

4.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And Priya, who notices everything and says almost none of it.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya standing a little apart from the group, watching everyone quietly with a drink, her eyes landing on the protagonist. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot, protagonist soft in foreground. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: observant, quiet.

CAMERA

medium shot,
protagonist soft in
foreground

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the
blue glow of a heated pool against
a cool night city skyline

MOOD

observant, quiet

ACTION

watching silently

009

SHOT

00:47

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Marcus taps a spoon against his glass. He gives a speech about thirty.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus tapping a spoon against his cocktail glass, guests turning toward him, the protagonist at the edge of the crowd. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: attention-grabbing.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

attention-grabbing

ACTION

tapping the glass

010

SHOT

00:51

3.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“About building something. About how everyone up here made it.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus giving a toast with one hand raised, speech-bubble icons of a house, a building and a trophy around him, guests cheering. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot from the crowd. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: triumphant, showy.

CAMERA

medium shot from the crowd

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

triumphant, showy

ACTION

gesturing grandly

011

SHOT

00:55

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He raises his drink toward Theo and Jenna's house, toward his own building, toward the city.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus raising his glass toward Theo and Jenna and then toward the luxury building behind him, the crowd's glasses lifting. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt; Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: celebratory, self-congratulatory.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

celebratory, self-congratulatory

ACTION

sweeping his glass across the room

012

SHOT

01:01

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“When his glass swings past you, it slows down for half a second. Then it keeps going.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus's glass sweeping past the protagonist and slowing for a beat, Marcus's smile flickering awkwardly, the protagonist deadpan. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: awkward, subtle exclusion.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

awkward, subtle exclusion

ACTION

the glass pausing near him

013

SHOT

01:07

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The waiter comes by with a tablet. Marcus waves him off. Tonight's on me, he says.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A young waiter in a black apron offering a payment tablet, Marcus waving him away with a flick of his hand. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt; the waiter is a young man in a black apron. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: generous, showy.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

generous, showy

ACTION

Marcus waving off the bill

014

SHOT

01:13

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Then he turns to you, grinning, warm, a little loud. And you're still at your mom's, right?”

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus turning toward the protagonist with a big, warm, loud grin, one arm around his shoulder. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: teasing, friendly.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

teasing, friendly

ACTION

throwing an arm around him

015

SHOT

01:19

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Still in the room with the stars on the ceiling? Everybody laughs. Not mean. Just familiar. You laugh too.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A thought bubble above the group showing a childhood bedroom ceiling covered in glowing plastic stars, the protagonist below it. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with thought bubble. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: embarrassing, nostalgic.

CAMERA

medium shot with
thought bubble

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the
blue glow of a heated pool against
a cool night city skyline

MOOD

embarrassing,
nostalgic

ACTION

everyone imagining the
bedroom

016

SHOT

01:27

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Jenna touches your arm. If you ever need a place, she says, we have the spare room now. Seriously. No rush.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Jenna touching the protagonist's arm kindly with a sympathetic expression. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: kind, pitying.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the
blue glow of a heated pool against
a cool night city skyline

MOOD

kind, pitying

ACTION

Jenna resting her hand
on his arm

017

SHOT

01:34

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You say thanks. You mean it. You're thirty. You still sleep in the bedroom you slept in at nine.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Split frame: the protagonist on the rooftop at thirty, and a small inset of the same bedroom with a twin bed and a nine-year-old version of him sleeping. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen medium shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: ironic, intimate.

CAMERA

split-screen medium
shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the
blue glow of a heated pool against
a cool night city skyline

MOOD

ironic, intimate

ACTION

standing still at the
railing

018

SHOT

01:41

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And sitting on that rooftop, you have more money than anyone holding a glass. Not more income.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist at the railing with faint gold numbers floating behind him like a ghostly bank balance, friends' glasses glinting beside him. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: secret wealth, quiet power.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

secret wealth,
quiet power

ACTION

gazing at the city

019

SHOT

01:48

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“More money. The kind that stays. None of them know. Not Marcus. Not Theo. Not Jenna. Not even Priya.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The four friends laughing in a row, each with a small question-mark icon over their heads, the protagonist watching them. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: secret, ironic.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

secret, ironic

ACTION

friends laughing unaware

020

SHOT

01:55

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Here's what nobody tells you about the years everyone pities you. They don't feel like a plan.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist alone in a spotlight on a dark stage, a faint crowd of pitying faces around the edges. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide stylized shot. Lighting: dramatic single spotlight in darkness. Mood: introspective, revealing.

CAMERA

wide stylized shot

LIGHTING

dramatic single spotlight in darkness

MOOD

introspective,
revealing

ACTION

standing still in the
spotlight

021

SHOT

02:01

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“They feel like an apology you keep making at every dinner. This is how the friend everyone assumed was stuck turned out”

IMAGE PROMPT

A montage of dinner tables with the protagonist apologizing with a raised hand at each one, friends' faces skeptical. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: three-panel montage. Lighting: warm dining light. Mood: weary, repetitive.

CAMERA

three-panel montage

LIGHTING

warm dining light

MOODweary,
repetitive**ACTION**raising his hand
apologetically**022**

SHOT

02:09

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“to be the only one not paying for someone else's house. And why saying it out loud kept getting harder.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A row of houses with tiny strings attached to the friends' hands like puppets, and the protagonist standing free with no strings. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide metaphorical shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: revealing, ironic.

CAMERA

wide metaphorical shot

LIGHTINGwarm golden string lights and the
blue glow of a heated pool against
a cool night city skyline**MOOD**

revealing, ironic

ACTIONthe protagonist standing
apart

STAGE 2 OF 11

The Driveway and the Rule

Age 22 · Four boxes and one decision

Shots 23–45 · 23 images

02:17 – 04:43

023
SHOT02:17
5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Eight years earlier, you're twenty-two, standing in your parents' driveway with everything you own”

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist in the driveway with arms full, a modest two-story family house behind him. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: flat cool overcast light. Mood: humble, uncertain.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium-wide shot	flat cool overcast light	humble, uncertain	holding a box

024
SHOT02:22
6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“in four cardboard boxes and a laundry basket. You have a degree. A job offer. \$41,000 a year.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist holding a diploma and an offer letter reading "Salary: \$41,000", the house behind him. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: flat cool overcast light. Mood: modest achievement.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	flat cool overcast light	modest achievement	holding up the papers

025
SHOT02:28
7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You also have \$19,000 in student loans and \$2,500 in a checking account. Your net worth sits around negative sixteen thousand.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of a laptop showing "Student Loans: \$19,000" and "Checking: \$2,500" on a cluttered desk. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: heavy, sobering.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones	heavy, sobering	the numbers glowing on screen

026

SHOT

02:36

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You tell everyone the same thing. Just for a few months. Just until I get settled.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist on the phone in the driveway, holding up one finger, a speech bubble reading "Just a few months". The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: flat cool overcast light. Mood: reassuring, unconvincing.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

flat cool overcast light

MOODreassuring,
unconvincing**ACTION**

talking on the phone

027

SHOT

02:42

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Your mother has cleared out the closet. She's washed the old comforter. She hasn't touched the ceiling.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A modest childhood bedroom with an emptied closet and a freshly washed blue comforter folded on a twin bed, his mother smoothing it. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot of the bedroom. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: caring, nostalgic.

CAMERAwide shot of the
bedroom**LIGHTING**flat cool lamp light, washed-out
blue-gray tones**MOOD**

caring, nostalgic

ACTIONhis mother smoothing
the comforter**028**

SHOT

02:48

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Thirty-one glow-in-the-dark stars, stuck up there when you were nine. They still light up faintly when you turn the lamp off.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of thirty-one yellowed glow-in-the-dark plastic stars stuck to a white ceiling in a childish pattern. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: nostalgic, small.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTINGflat cool lamp light, washed-out
blue-gray tones**MOOD**

nostalgic, small

ACTION

the stars on the ceiling

029

SHOT

02:56

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The spare key is on the hook by the door. Same faded blue lanyard from high school.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A hallway by the front door with a wall hook holding a single brass key on a faded blue lanyard. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: homey, symbolic.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTINGflat cool lamp light, washed-out
blue-gray tones**MOOD**

homey, symbolic

ACTIONthe key hanging on the
hook

030

SHOT

03:02

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Your mother hands it to you like it's a formality. Like you never gave it back.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother handing the younger protagonist the key on the blue lanyard in the hallway, smiling softly. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: warm, matter-of-fact.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

warm, matter-of-fact

ACTION

placing the key in his hand

031

SHOT

03:08

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The first night, you lie under the stars and open a rental app.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist lying in bed under the glowing stars, his face lit by a phone showing a rental listing app. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot from above. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: curious, wistful.

CAMERA

medium shot from above

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

curious, wistful

ACTION

scrolling the app

032

SHOT

03:13

4.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“A one-bedroom across town. \$1,450 a month. Plus utilities. Plus parking.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone screen showing an apartment listing “1BR Across Town \$1,450/mo” with small icons for utilities and parking. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: tempting.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

tempting

ACTION

the listing on screen

033

SHOT

03:17

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Call it \$1,700. That’s what being a grown-up costs in this city. That’s the number everyone your age is paying.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone calculator showing “\$1,700” with a small grown-up figure in a suit icon beside it. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: sobering.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

sobering

ACTION

the total glowing

034

SHOT

03:25

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And then you make a decision so small it feels like nothing. You’ll pay it anyway.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist lying still under the stars, a tiny lightbulb icon appearing faintly over his head. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: quiet decision.

CAMERA

medium close-up

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

quiet decision

ACTION

his eyes narrowing in thought

035

SHOT

03:31

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Every month, \$1,700 leaves your paycheck, just like it would if you had your own place.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A split image: the younger protagonist paying into a jar labeled “RENT” in his childhood bedroom, and a stranger paying a landlord. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the landlord is a smug middle-aged man in an expensive suit. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen medium shot. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: parallel, deliberate.

CAMERA

split-screen medium shot

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

parallel, deliberate

ACTION

dropping money into the jar

036

SHOT

03:37

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“\$500 goes to your parents. They try to refuse it. Your mother pushes the first envelope back across the kitchen table.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother pushing the envelope back across a worn kitchen table with two fingers. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on the table. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: loving resistance.

CAMERA

close-up on the table

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOOD

loving resistance

ACTION

sliding the envelope back

037

SHOT

03:44

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You push it back harder. She takes it the way people take something they plan to argue about later.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother slowly picking up the envelope with a skeptical, pursed-lip expression. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on his mother. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: reluctant, unfinished.

CAMERA

close-up on his mother

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOODreluctant,
unfinished**ACTION**

lifting the envelope

038

SHOT

03:51

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The other \$1,200 disappears the morning the paycheck lands. Automatic. Gone before you can miss it.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone notification at dawn reading "Auto-transfer: \$1,200 → Investment Account" on a nightstand beside a buzzing alarm clock. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: cool early-morning light. Mood: automatic, quiet.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

cool early-morning light

MOOD

automatic, quiet

ACTIONthe notification lighting
up**039**

SHOT

03:57

5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“One rule. Made once. So you'd never have to decide again. You tell no one.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A single sticky note on the bedroom mirror reading "One rule.", the younger protagonist's reflection behind it. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up through the mirror. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: simple, firm.

CAMERAmedium close-up
through the mirror**LIGHTING**flat cool lamp light, washed-out
blue-gray tones**MOOD**

simple, firm

ACTION

looking at the note

040

SHOT

04:03

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“There's no way to say it that doesn't sound like an excuse. I live with my parents, but it's on purpose”

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist with an empty speech bubble struggling to fill it, crossed-out words scribbled inside. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: awkward, unexplainable.

CAMERA

medium close-up

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

awkward, unexplainable

ACTION

trying to find words

041

SHOT

04:11

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“isn't a sentence anyone believes at twenty-two. The next morning, your father is at the kitchen table with his coffee”

IMAGE PROMPT

Morning kitchen, his father at the table with coffee, the younger protagonist in the background. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot of the kitchen. Lighting: soft cool morning light. Mood: ordinary, quiet.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot of the kitchen

LIGHTING

soft cool morning light

MOOD

ordinary, quiet

ACTION

his father sipping coffee

042

SHOT

04:18

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“and the newspaper he still pays for. He watches you pack a lunch in a reused takeout container.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist packing leftovers into a reused takeout container at the counter, his father watching over the newspaper. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft cool morning light. Mood: frugal, observed.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

soft cool morning light

MOOD

frugal, observed

ACTION

snapping the lid shut

043

SHOT

04:25

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You sure about this? he asks. Not the living here. The other thing. He saw the envelope.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His father lowering the newspaper and asking a question with a raised eyebrow. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up on his father. Lighting: soft cool morning light. Mood: curious, protective.

CAMERA

medium close-up on his father

LIGHTING

soft cool morning light

MOOD

curious, protective

ACTION

lowering the paper

044

SHOT

04:31

4.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He doesn't know what the rest of the money is doing.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His father squinting thoughtfully, a thought bubble with a question mark and a dollar sign. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on his father. Lighting: soft cool morning light. Mood: puzzled.

CAMERA

close-up on his father

LIGHTING

soft cool morning light

MOOD

puzzled

ACTION

thinking

045

SHOT

04:35

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He just knows you're doing something. You say you're sure. You aren't. He nods and turns the page. He never asks again.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist nodding at his father with a small deadpan nod, a tiny sweat drop on his temple. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft cool morning light. Mood: uncertain bravado.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

soft cool morning light

MOOD

uncertain bravado

ACTION

nodding

STAGE 3 OF 11

"So When Are You Moving Out?"

Age 22–23 · The question that never stops

Shots 46–64 · 19 images
04:43 – 06:47

046

SHOT

04:43

7.8s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

"That first summer, Marcus throws a party at his new apartment. Exposed brick. A balcony. A dog-friendly building with no dog."

IMAGE PROMPT

A lively apartment party with exposed brick walls, Marcus hosting with a drink in hand. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: warm party lighting. Mood: trendy, social.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

warm party lighting

MOOD

trendy, social

ACTION

Marcus welcoming guests

047

SHOT

04:51

6.7s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

"Someone asks where everyone's living now, and the answers go around the circle like a toast. Downtown. Midtown."

IMAGE PROMPT

Speech bubbles going around the circle reading "Downtown", "Midtown", each friend raising a glass. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm party lighting. Mood: proud, competitive.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm party lighting

MOOD

proud, competitive

ACTION

glasses raising

048

SHOT

04:58

7.0s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

"That place by the river. Then they get to you. You say, I'm at my parents' for a bit."

IMAGE PROMPT

A final bubble "By the river", then everyone turning to look at the younger protagonist. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm party lighting. Mood: expectant.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

warm party lighting

MOOD

expectant

ACTION

heads turning

049

SHOT

05:05

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And a small silence opens up. Not cruel. Just careful. The kind of silence people make”

IMAGE PROMPT

The circle of friends frozen mid-sip with polite, uncomfortable smiles. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm party lighting. Mood: awkward, careful.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm party lighting

MOODawkward,
careful**ACTION**

everyone going still

050

SHOT

05:11

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“around something they don't want to step on. Then Theo asks the question. Not unkindly. Just curious.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo leaning forward on the couch with a curious, friendly expression. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up on Theo. Lighting: warm party lighting. Mood: innocent curiosity.

CAMERAmedium close-up on
Theo**LIGHTING**

warm party lighting

MOODinnocent
curiosity**ACTION**

asking the question

051

SHOT

05:17

5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“So when are you moving out? You say soon. Everyone nods. The conversation rolls on.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist answering, friends nodding and turning back to each other. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium group shot. Lighting: warm party lighting. Mood: brushed off.

CAMERA

medium group shot

LIGHTING

warm party lighting

MOOD

brushed off

ACTIONthe conversation moving
on

052

SHOT

05:22

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"You'll hear that question for eight years. Thanksgiving that year, it gets asked by people who don't love you as gently."

IMAGE PROMPT

Relatives at the table leaning toward the younger protagonist with nosy, judgmental expressions. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the relatives are a mix of middle-aged and older family members in festive sweaters. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: judgmental.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm golden dining light

MOOD

judgmental

ACTION

relatives leaning in

053

SHOT

05:30

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"Your aunt Denise sets down a dish of sweet potatoes and asks, so where are you living now, honey?"

IMAGE PROMPT

Aunt Denise setting down a dish of sweet potatoes and turning to the younger protagonist with a fake sweet smile. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Aunt Denise is a heavyset woman in her sixties with teased hair and a bold red blouse. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: nosy, sugary.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

warm golden dining light

MOOD

nosy, sugary

ACTION

setting down the dish

054

SHOT

05:37

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"Before you can answer, your mother says, he's home with us, and something in the room adjusts. Your cousin Kyle is twenty-four."

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother cutting in protectively, a hand raised, the younger protagonist beside her. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: defensive, loving.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden dining light

MOODdefensive,
loving**ACTION**his mother answering for
him

055

SHOT

05:45

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"He just bought a truck. \$640 a month for seventy-two months. He announces the payment like it's a trophy."

IMAGE PROMPT

Cousin Kyle holding up a phone photo of a shiny new pickup truck with a "\$640/mo x 72" overlay. Character notes: Cousin Kyle is a broad young man in a trucker cap and a team jersey. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: showy, financed.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm golden dining light

MOOD

showy, financed

ACTION

showing the photo

056

SHOT

05:52

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"Your uncle claps him on the back. Then he looks at you, and the hand doesn't come."

IMAGE PROMPT

His uncle turning toward the younger protagonist, his hand hovering and then dropping to his side. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his uncle is a loud gray-haired man in a sweater vest. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: withheld approval.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden dining light

MOODwithheld
approval**ACTION**

the hand not coming

057

SHOT

05:59

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"He just says, well, no rush, buddy. Everybody's on their own timeline. It's kind. It's also a verdict. You pass the rolls."

IMAGE PROMPT

His uncle giving a tight, condescending smile while the younger protagonist sits deadpan. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his uncle is a loud gray-haired man in a sweater vest. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: patronizing.

CAMERA

medium close-up

LIGHTING

warm golden dining light

MOOD

patronizing

ACTIONoffering hollow
reassurance

058

SHOT

06:07

5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"You notice nobody asks you a single follow-up question for the rest of the night."

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist eating quietly at the end of the table while relatives chat animatedly with Kyle. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Cousin Kyle is a broad young man in a trucker cap and a team jersey; the relatives are a mix of middle-aged and older family members in festive sweaters. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm golden dining light. Mood: ignored.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm golden dining light

MOOD

ignored

ACTION

eating silently

059

SHOT

06:12

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"The first fourteen months, the \$1,200 doesn't build anything. It erases. Loan statements shrink. \$19,000. Then \$13,000. Then \$6,400."

IMAGE PROMPT

A bank app screen showing a "\$1,200" payment hitting a student loan, the loan bar shrinking. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: focused, erasing.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

focused, erasing

ACTION

the bar shrinking

060

SHOT

06:19

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"You make the last payment from your car in a grocery store parking lot on a Tuesday."

IMAGE PROMPT

Exterior of a grocery store parking lot on a gray Tuesday, his old sedan parked alone, a calendar overlay showing Tuesday. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: flat cool overcast light. Mood: ordinary.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

flat cool overcast light

MOOD

ordinary

ACTION

the car sitting still

061

SHOT

06:26

5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"The screen says balance zero. You sit there with the engine off. Nobody to tell."

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone screen reading "Loan Balance: \$0.00" with the younger protagonist's still face reflected above it. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool overcast light. Mood: quiet triumph.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool overcast light

MOOD

quiet triumph

ACTION

the engine off

062

SHOT

06:31

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"You drive home and eat leftovers at the same kitchen table you ate cereal at in fourth grade."

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist eating leftovers alone at a worn kitchen table at night. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: humble, ordinary.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOODhumble,
ordinary**ACTION**

eating quietly

063

SHOT

06:38

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"The next month, the \$1,200 finds a new home. An index fund."

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone screen showing "Auto-transfer: \$1,200 → Index Fund" with a small seedling icon. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: new beginning.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTINGflat cool lamp light, washed-out
blue-gray tones**MOOD**

new beginning

ACTIONthe transfer going
through**064**

SHOT

06:42

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

"The first deposit buys a few shares of something you'll never see."

IMAGE PROMPT

Tiny share icons dropping into a dark, opaque box labeled "Index Fund". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up metaphor. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: invisible growth.

CAMERA

close-up metaphor

LIGHTINGflat cool lamp light, washed-out
blue-gray tones**MOOD**

invisible growth

ACTION

shares dropping in

STAGE 4 OF 11

The Invisible Years

Age 23–24 · Everyone else's life, in pictures

Shots 65–88 · 24 images

06:47 – 09:16

065
SHOT06:47
4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Then come the years where it looks like you made a mistake.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist standing still on a busy sidewalk while everyone else walks quickly past him in a blur. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: soft neutral daylight. Mood: stuck, doubtful.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

soft neutral daylight

MOOD

stuck, doubtful

ACTION

standing still

066
SHOT06:51
7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Because everyone else's life starts happening on schedule. In public. With pictures. Theo and Jenna buy a house at twenty-five.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A group chat on a phone screen filling with photos of friends' new homes, cars and vacations, the younger protagonist's thumb scrolling. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: envious, public.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out
blue-gray tones

MOOD

envious, public

ACTION

scrolling the feed

067
SHOT06:59
5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“A small one with a red door and a backyard that floods when it rains.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A backyard with a large muddy puddle spreading across the grass in the rain. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: cool rainy light. Mood: foreshadowing.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

cool rainy light

MOOD

foreshadowing

ACTION

rain pooling in the yard

068

SHOT

07:04

3.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The group chat fills with paint swatches. Then a puppy.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A phone group chat filled with paint swatch photos and then a photo of a fluffy puppy. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: cheerful, domestic.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

cheerful, domestic

ACTION

new photos popping in

069

SHOT

07:08

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Then a photo of keys in Jenna's hand, a ribbon tied around them. Someone writes, adults. Thirty hearts follow.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up photo on a phone of a house key in Jenna's hand tied with a red ribbon. Character notes: Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: celebratory.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones

MOOD

celebratory

ACTION

the key photo appearing

070

SHOT

07:15

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Marcus moves again. A higher floor. A gym in the basement. A doorman who learns his name. His rent climbs to \$2,100.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus moving into a sleek high-rise apartment, a movers' dolly and a basement gym visible through glass. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: upward, flashy.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

upward, flashy

ACTION

Marcus carrying a box

071

SHOT

07:23

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He mentions it the way people mention the price of a watch.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus casually showing off a luxury wristwatch while mentioning his rent, friends nodding. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: braggish.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

braggish

ACTION

tapping his watch

072

SHOT

07:28

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Your updates get smaller. Then they stop. What are you going to post? A photo of your mother's meatloaf? The ceiling?”

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist's phone showing his own social profile with an empty feed and a blinking cursor. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: invisible.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

invisible

ACTION

the cursor blinking

073

SHOT

07:35

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You go on a date. Her name is Alana. She's funny and quick, and she likes the same terrible movie you do.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Alana laughing at a joke, the younger protagonist almost smiling, a movie poster on the restaurant wall. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Alana is a lively woman with curly black hair and a rust-colored sweater. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm candle light. Mood: easy chemistry.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm candle light

MOOD

easy chemistry

ACTION

laughing together

074

SHOT

07:44

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Halfway through dinner she asks where you live. You tell her the truth.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Alana leaning in with a curious question, the younger protagonist answering honestly. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Alana is a lively woman with curly black hair and a rust-colored sweater. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm candle light. Mood: honest, risky.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm candle light

MOOD

honest, risky

ACTION

talking over dinner

075

SHOT

07:48

5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She says, oh. Just that. Oh. Her face doesn't change much. It just closes, gently,”

IMAGE PROMPT

Alana's polite smile freezing, a tiny speech bubble reading "Oh.". Character notes: Alana is a lively woman with curly black hair and a rust-colored sweater. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on Alana. Lighting: warm candle light. Mood: cooling.

CAMERA

close-up on Alana

LIGHTING

warm candle light

MOOD

cooling

ACTION

her smile stiffening

076

SHOT

07:54

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“like a door being shut so it won't wake anyone. When the check comes,”

IMAGE PROMPT

A visual metaphor of a door being gently closed in a dark hallway. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: dim hallway light. Mood: soft finality.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

dim hallway light

MOOD

soft finality

ACTION

the door clicking shut

077

SHOT

07:59

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“she reaches for her half before you can reach for all of it. Not rude. Efficient. You're being placed in a category,”

IMAGE PROMPT

Alana quickly sliding her card into the check folder before the younger protagonist can reach for it. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Alana is a lively woman with curly black hair and a rust-colored sweater. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on hands. Lighting: warm candle light. Mood: efficient, distant.

CAMERA

close-up on hands

LIGHTING

warm candle light

MOOD

efficient, distant

ACTION

her card going in first

078

SHOT

08:07

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“and the category doesn't get a second date. You drive home and park in the same spot in the driveway.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist's old sedan pulling into his parents' driveway at night, parking in the same spot. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his parents are a small graying woman in a faded maroon cardigan and a heavyset gray-mustached man in a plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: cool night light. Mood: routine, quiet.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

cool night light

MOOD

routine, quiet

ACTION

the car pulling in

079

SHOT

08:15

3.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Your father's left the porch light on. He always does.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A warm porch light glowing above the front door of the modest family house at night. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm porch light against cool night. Mood: welcoming, steady.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

warm porch light against cool night

MOODwelcoming,
steady**ACTION**

the porch light shining

080

SHOT

08:18

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The rule runs the entire time. Every raise, half disappears into the account. \$1,200 becomes \$1,400. Then \$1,650. You never feel richer.”

IMAGE PROMPT

An automatic transfer arrow on a phone screen moving money from "Paycheck" to "Account" every month on a calendar strip. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: relentless, steady.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTINGflat cool lamp light, washed-out
blue-gray tones**MOOD**relentless,
steady**ACTION**

the arrow repeating

081

SHOT

08:27

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You change a number in an app and go back to work. At work, the team goes to lunch on Fridays.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The younger protagonist at an office desk changing a number in a banking app, then turning back to his monitor. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: flat cool office fluorescent light. Mood: routine, unremarkable.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

flat cool office fluorescent light

MOODroutine,
unremarkable**ACTION**tapping and returning to
work**082**

SHOT

08:34

5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Everyone talks about rent the way people talk about weather. Somebody's landlord raised it \$150.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Coworkers chatting animatedly about rent with weather-style icons (sun, clouds, rain) floating above them. Character notes: the coworkers are young office workers in business-casual clothes. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: everyday, comparative.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOODeveryday,
comparative**ACTION**

coworkers talking

083

SHOT

08:40

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Somebody else found a place with in-unit laundry for only \$1,900. Your manager, Greg,”

IMAGE PROMPT

Another coworker excitedly showing an apartment listing "In-unit laundry \$1,900". Character notes: the coworker is a nervous young man in a wrinkled dress shirt and loosened tie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: excited.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

excited

ACTION

holding up the listing

084

SHOT

08:45

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“a nice man with three kids and a boat he never uses, turns to you. And where are you these days?”

IMAGE PROMPT

A small thought bubble above Greg showing three kids and an unused boat under a tarp. Character notes: Greg is a friendly balding middle-aged manager in a tucked-in navy polo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with thought bubble. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: wholesome, suburban.

CAMERAmedium shot with
thought bubble**LIGHTING**

soft clean daylight

MOODwholesome,
suburban**ACTION**

Greg chuckling

085

SHOT

08:53

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You say you're at home for now. He nods slowly. At your review, he gives you the biggest raise on the team.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A performance review meeting in a glass office, Greg handing over a document reading "Raise: Top of team". Character notes: Greg is a friendly balding middle-aged manager in a tucked-in navy polo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: flat cool office fluorescent light. Mood: rewarding.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

flat cool office fluorescent light

MOOD

rewarding

ACTION

handing the paper

086

SHOT

09:01

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He says it's for your work. Then he adds, quietly, maybe this helps you get your own place.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Greg leaning in and speaking quietly with a hopeful expression, a thought bubble showing a little apartment. Character notes: Greg is a friendly balding middle-aged manager in a tucked-in navy polo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: flat cool office fluorescent light. Mood: kind, assuming.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

flat cool office fluorescent light

MOOD

kind, assuming

ACTION

leaning in

087

SHOT

09:08

3.7s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“He means well. He thinks he's paying for your escape.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Greg patting the younger protagonist's shoulder with a warm, hopeful smile. The younger protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a plain charcoal hoodie, thinner and more tired, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Greg is a friendly balding middle-aged manager in a tucked-in navy polo. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: flat cool office fluorescent light. Mood: well-meaning.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	flat cool office fluorescent light	well-meaning	the shoulder pat

088

SHOT

09:11

4.8s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“He doesn't know half of it will be in the account by Monday.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone screen on Monday morning showing half the raise transferring to "Investment Account". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones. Mood: quiet, secret.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	flat cool lamp light, washed-out blue-gray tones	quiet, secret	the transfer completing

STAGE 5 OF 11

The Loft and the Mortgage

Age 25 · The pen, the envelope, the \$800

Shots 89–115 · 27 images
09:16 – 12:07

089

SHOT

09:16

6.3s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“Two things happen in those years that you won't understand until later. The first is an apartment.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist sitting on his childhood bed looking up at the plastic stars, two small question-mark icons above him. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: foreshadowing.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars	foreshadowing	looking up

090

SHOT

09:22

7.4s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“You're twenty-five and you're tired of explaining yourself. So you go look at a loft downtown. Brick walls. Tall windows.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A sunlit downtown loft with exposed brick walls and tall factory windows, the protagonist standing in the middle. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide one-point-perspective shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: aspirational.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide one-point-perspective shot	soft clean daylight	aspirational	looking around

091

SHOT

09:30

6.7s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“A kitchen with a gas stove and a little shelf for spices you don't own. \$1,650 a month.”

IMAGE PROMPT

An empty wooden spice shelf on the loft kitchen wall beside a sign reading "\$1,650/mo". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: tempting, hollow.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	soft clean daylight	tempting, hollow	the empty shelf

092

SHOT

09:37

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You can afford it. That's the problem. It isn't reckless. It's just more. The leasing agent is about your age.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist holding a paycheck stub next to the "\$1,650" listing, both balanced on a scale. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: conflicted.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft clean daylight	conflicted	weighing the papers

093

SHOT

09:44

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She's wearing a blazer and she's very good at her job. She slides the lease across a glass desk”

IMAGE PROMPT

The leasing agent confidently presenting a glossy brochure. Character notes: the leasing agent is a polished young woman in a fitted gray blazer. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot on the leasing agent. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: polished, persuasive.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot on the leasing agent	soft clean daylight	polished, persuasive	presenting the brochure

094

SHOT

09:51

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“and sets a pen on top of it. Everything about the room says, you belong here. You pick up the pen.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist picking up the pen in the stylish office, motivational wall art reading "Welcome Home" behind him. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: tempted.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft clean daylight	tempted	lifting the pen

095

SHOT

09:59

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And you stand there long enough that she starts to smile less.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist frozen with the pen hovering over the signature line, the leasing agent's smile slowly fading. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the leasing agent is a polished young woman in a fitted gray blazer. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: tense, hesitant.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	soft clean daylight	tense, hesitant	hovering the pen

096

SHOT

10:03

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You put the pen down. You say you need to think. She says the unit won't last. You say you understand.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist setting the pen back down on the unsigned lease. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on the desk. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: restraint.

CAMERA

close-up on the desk

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

restraint

ACTION

placing the pen down

097

SHOT

10:11

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“That night the group chat lights up. Marcus on his balcony. City behind him. A caption with three fire emojis.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A phone screen at night showing a group chat photo of Marcus posing on his balcony. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: envious.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

envious

ACTION

the photo appearing

098

SHOT

10:18

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And you lie under thirty-one plastic stars, wondering if you're building something”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist lying on his childhood bed staring up at thirty-one glowing plastic stars. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: high-angle shot. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: lonely, reflective.

CAMERA

high-angle shot

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

lonely, reflective

ACTION

lying still

099

SHOT

10:23

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“or just getting very good at hiding from your own life. You don't feel disciplined. You feel behind.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist curled under the blanket while faint shadows of a life passing by move across the ceiling. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: avoidant, uncertain.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

avoidant, uncertain

ACTION

pulling the blanket up

100

SHOT

10:29

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Priya is the only one who ever gets close. At a bar that year, she watches you order water with lime”

IMAGE PROMPT

A busy bar, the protagonist ordering water with lime from a bartender, Priya beside him noticing. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket; the bartender is a tattooed young woman in a black tee. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm bar lighting. Mood: frugal, noticed.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm bar lighting

MOOD

frugal, noticed

ACTION

holding the water glass

101

SHOT

10:37

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“while everyone else orders the second round. She doesn't make a joke about it.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Friends ordering a second round of colorful cocktails while the protagonist sips water. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm bar lighting. Mood: contrast.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm bar lighting

MOOD

contrast

ACTION

glasses being refilled

102

SHOT

10:42

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She just slides her fries toward the middle of the table, where you can reach them.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya sliding a basket of fries toward the center of the table. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on the table. Lighting: warm bar lighting. Mood: quiet kindness.

CAMERA

close-up on the table

LIGHTING

warm bar lighting

MOOD

quiet kindness

ACTION

sliding the fries

103

SHOT

10:48

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Later, in the parking lot, she asks if you're okay for money. Not pity. Just a question. You tell her you're fine.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A dark parking lot outside the bar, Priya asking a quiet question beside the protagonist's car. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: cool night streetlight. Mood: concerned.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

cool night streetlight

MOOD

concerned

ACTION

leaning against the car

104

SHOT

10:57

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She looks at your car, then at you, and says, okay. She doesn't believe you. She just decides not to push.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya glancing at the protagonist's old dented sedan and then back at him. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: cool night streetlight. Mood: skeptical, kind.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

cool night streetlight

MOOD

skeptical, kind

ACTION

looking at the car

105

SHOT

11:04

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You'll think about that parking lot for years. The second thing, you almost miss.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The empty parking lot under a single streetlight after everyone has left. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: cool night streetlight. Mood: memorable, quiet.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

cool night streetlight

MOOD

memorable,
quiet

ACTION

the lot sitting empty

106

SHOT

11:10

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Your father's hours get cut. Not fired. Just cut. Thirty hours a week instead of forty. Your parents don't tell you.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A weekly schedule sheet with forty hours crossed out and "30 HRS" written in red. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: flat cool light. Mood: financial strain.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

flat cool light

MOOD

financial strain

ACTION

the red marks

107

SHOT

11:17

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You find out from the envelope on the counter with the bank's logo,”

IMAGE PROMPT

An envelope with a bank logo lying on a kitchen counter, the protagonist picking it up. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: discovery.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOOD

discovery

ACTION

lifting the envelope

108

SHOT

11:22

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“opened and refolded too many times. The mortgage. \$1,180 a month. Eleven years left.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A mortgage statement creased from being folded many times, showing "\$1,180/month". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: heavy.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOOD

heavy

ACTION

the creases visible

109

SHOT

11:27

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You don't ask. You just change one number. Starting that month, \$800 goes to your parents instead of \$500.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A banking app screen changing a transfer from "\$500" to "\$800" labeled "Parents". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: generous, silent.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight, neutral tones

MOOD

generous, silent

ACTION

the number changing

110

SHOT

11:34

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You tell your mother it's because you eat more than you used to.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist handing his mother a thicker envelope, smiling awkwardly, a plate of food in his other hand. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: playful excuse.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOOD

playful excuse

ACTION

handing the envelope

111

SHOT

11:39

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She looks at you a long time. She doesn't argue. You don't know it yet, but that \$800 isn't going to groceries.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A grocery bag sitting empty on the counter while the "\$800" envelope slides past it. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: redirected.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOOD

redirected

ACTION

the envelope bypassing the groceries

112

SHOT

11:47

5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Your mother is sending every dollar of it straight to the principal on the house.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother at the kitchen table at night filling out a mortgage payment slip with the "\$800" envelope beside it. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: secret devotion.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

secret devotion

ACTION

writing on the slip

113

SHOT

11:53

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And for almost four years, the plan doesn't make you feel smart.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist at his desk looking at a calendar with four years crossed out, his expression flat. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: unsatisfied.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

unsatisfied

ACTION

staring at the calendar

114

SHOT

11:57

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“It makes everyone else look like they started living years before you did. You have no way of knowing”

IMAGE PROMPT

Split frame: friends traveling and celebrating on one side, the protagonist in his childhood bedroom on the other. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: left behind.

CAMERA

split-screen medium
shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

left behind

ACTION

scrolling his phone

115

SHOT

12:04

3.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“the distance between you is already turning around.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A scale slowly tipping toward the protagonist's side while friends' side rises, unnoticed by everyone. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium metaphorical shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: turning tide.

CAMERA

medium metaphorical
shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

turning tide

ACTION

the scale beginning to
shift

STAGE 6 OF 11

The Crash

Age 26 · When fear doesn't get a vote

Shots 116-138 · 23 images

12:07 – 14:34

116
SHOT12:07
4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You're twenty-six when the market falls apart. Not a dip. A real one.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A red market crash graph plunging on a TV screen in a family living room. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: cool TV glow in a dim living room. Mood: alarming.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

cool TV glow in a dim living room

MOOD

alarming

ACTION

the line falling

117
SHOT12:12
7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The kind that leads the evening news in your parents' living room while your father shakes his head at the screen.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His parents' living room with the evening news showing a "MARKET CRASH" headline. Character notes: his parents are a small graying woman in a faded maroon cardigan and a heavyset gray-mustached man in a plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: cool TV glow in a dim living room. Mood: anxious.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

cool TV glow in a dim living room

MOOD

anxious

ACTION

the news playing

118
SHOT12:20
7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Over four bad months, your account loses twenty-two percent. At work, people say, did you see what the market did?”

IMAGE PROMPT

Coworkers gathered around a monitor with shocked faces looking at falling stock charts. Character notes: the coworkers are young office workers in business-casual clothes. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: flat cool office fluorescent light. Mood: panicked.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

flat cool office fluorescent light

MOOD

panicked

ACTION

pointing at the screen

119
SHOT12:27
5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“in the voice you'd use for a car accident. A guy two desks over sells everything”

IMAGE PROMPT

Coworkers speaking in hushed, grim tones as if discussing a car accident. Character notes: the coworkers are young office workers in business-casual clothes. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: flat cool office fluorescent light. Mood: grave.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

flat cool office fluorescent light

MOOD

grave

ACTION

whispering

120

SHOT

12:33

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“on a Thursday afternoon and goes home early. He tells you he's done gambling. You nod.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The same coworker grabbing his coat and leaving early, a calendar showing Thursday. Character notes: the coworker is a nervous young man in a wrinkled dress shirt and loosened tie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: flat cool office fluorescent light. Mood: defeated.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	flat cool office fluorescent light	defeated	walking out

121

SHOT

12:39

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You open the app at work and watch \$31,000 turn into \$24,000. That year, you put in more than \$19,000.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of a phone screen showing a balance dropping from "\$31,000" to "\$24,000". Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: painful, stark.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	soft clean daylight, neutral tones	painful, stark	the number falling

122

SHOT

12:47

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And in December the balance is lower than it was in January. Theo's house is still standing. Marcus's view is still there.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A balance chart comparing December lower than January with a red arrow pointing down. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: frustrating.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	soft clean daylight, neutral tones	frustrating	the chart ending lower

123

SHOT

12:55

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Their choices didn't evaporate. Yours look like they did. You want to stop. You don't. Not because you're brave.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist's finger hovering over a "STOP TRANSFERS" button on his phone. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up over his hand. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: tempted.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up over his hand	soft clean daylight	tempted	hovering

124

SHOT

13:02

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Because the transfer was set up years ago, back before fear had a vote.”

IMAGE PROMPT

An old automatic transfer setting dated years ago on a dusty screen. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: automated discipline.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight, neutral tones

MOODautomated
discipline**ACTION**

the setting locked in

125

SHOT

13:07

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“It keeps buying while everything is on sale. You just can't feel that yet. It only feels like losing.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist staring at his phone with a downcast expression. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: discouraged.

CAMERA

close-up

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

discouraged

ACTION

staring blankly

126

SHOT

13:14

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“That night you lie under the ceiling and count the stars. Thirty-one.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in bed counting the glowing plastic stars on the ceiling with a slow finger. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: high-angle shot. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: steady, lonely.

CAMERA

high-angle shot

LIGHTINGdim warm bedside lamp light with
the faint green glow of plastic
ceiling stars**MOOD**

steady, lonely

ACTION

pointing at each star

127

SHOT

13:18

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Same as always. They're the only thing in your life that hasn't moved. Somewhere in that stretch, Marcus gets drinks with you”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the unchanged ceiling stars in the same pattern, glowing softly. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: constant.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTINGdim warm bedside lamp light with
the faint green glow of plastic
ceiling stars**MOOD**

constant

ACTION

the stars glowing

128

SHOT

13:27

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“and looks at the blue lanyard hanging out of your jacket pocket.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the faded blue lanyard dangling out of the protagonist's jacket pocket. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm bar lighting. Mood: nostalgic, noticed.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm bar lighting

MOODnostalgic,
noticed**ACTION**

the lanyard hanging out

129

SHOT

13:31

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You still carry that thing? he says. It's from high school. Let me buy you a key ring at least.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus pointing and laughing at the lanyard. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium close-up on Marcus. Lighting: warm bar lighting. Mood: teasing.

CAMERAmedium close-up on
Marcus**LIGHTING**

warm bar lighting

MOOD

teasing

ACTION

laughing

130

SHOT

13:38

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You tell him it's lucky. He lets it go. Then your car's transmission dies on the highway. \$2,300.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist tucking the lanyard back into his pocket, Marcus shrugging. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm bar lighting. Mood: private.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm bar lighting

MOOD

private

ACTION

tucking it away

131

SHOT

13:45

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The kind of bill that would have flattened you at twenty-two. You pay it from your checking account”

IMAGE PROMPT

A repair estimate reading "Transmission: \$2,300" held in the protagonist's hand. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: cool overcast daylight. Mood: daunting.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

cool overcast daylight

MOOD

daunting

ACTION

holding the estimate

132

SHOT

13:52

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“standing at the counter of the repair shop. The mechanic, an older man with grease in the creases of his knuckles,”

IMAGE PROMPT

An older mechanic with grease-stained knuckles behind the counter, watching closely. Character notes: the mechanic is an older man in blue coveralls with grease-stained knuckles. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot on the mechanic. Lighting: warm shop lighting. Mood: curious.

CAMERA

medium shot on the mechanic

LIGHTING

warm shop lighting

MOOD

curious

ACTION

wiping his hands

133

SHOT

14:00

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“waits for you to flinch. Most people do. You don't. He looks at you a second longer than usual.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The mechanic watching the protagonist's face for a flinch, the protagonist completely calm. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the mechanic is an older man in blue coveralls with grease-stained knuckles. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm shop lighting. Mood: tense, surprising.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm shop lighting

MOOD

tense, surprising

ACTION

holding his gaze

134

SHOT

14:07

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You're three steps into the parking lot before you realize you weren't afraid. The fear just wasn't there.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist walking across the repair shop parking lot, pausing mid-step with a dawning realization. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: surprised calm.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

surprised calm

ACTION

stopping mid-step

135

SHOT

14:13

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Somewhere in the boring years, without a date you could circle, it left. By twenty-seven, the market turns.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A pale ghost of fear drifting away from the protagonist over a montage of ordinary workdays. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium metaphorical shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: quiet transformation.

CAMERA

medium metaphorical shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

quiet transformation

ACTION

the ghost fading

136

SHOT

14:20

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The shares you bought in the fire start doing what shares do.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Tiny share icons sprouting into small green plants inside a glass box. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up metaphor. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: growth.

CAMERA

close-up metaphor

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight, neutral tones

MOOD

growth

ACTION

plants sprouting

137

SHOT

14:24

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The account doesn't just recover. It passes everything it was before. \$80,000. Then \$100,000 on an ordinary Wednesday.”

IMAGE PROMPT

An investment balance on a phone reading "\$80,000" with a green recovery graph. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: rewarding.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight, neutral tones

MOOD

rewarding

ACTION

the number climbing

138
SHOT

14:31
3.3s

- ☐ Image
- ☐ Animated
- ☐ Placed

“You notice it the way you'd notice the weather.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist glancing at his phone and then looking out a window at the weather with the same flat expression. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: nonchalant.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

nonchalant

ACTION

glancing outside

STAGE 7 OF 11

The Reversal

Age 27 · Lives that have to be fed

Shots 139–154 · 16 images

14:34 – 16:14

139
SHOT**14:34**

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And around that time, the reversal starts. Quiet. Invisible. Real. Theo and Jenna's interest rate resets. Their payment jumps \$640 a month.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo and Jenna at their kitchen table staring at a letter reading "New payment: +\$640/mo". Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: stressed.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

stressed

ACTION

holding the letter

140
SHOT**14:42**

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The same number as Kyle's truck. You notice it. You don't say it. Then the basement floods, the one that always flooded,”

IMAGE PROMPT

Split frame: the "+\$640" mortgage letter beside Cousin Kyle's "\$640/mo" truck photo. Character notes: Cousin Kyle is a broad young man in a trucker cap and a team jersey. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen close-up. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: ironic parallel.

CAMERA

split-screen close-up

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight, neutral tones

MOOD

ironic parallel

ACTION

both numbers matching

141
SHOT**14:51**

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“and this time it's \$9,000. Jenna mentions it at dinner like it's a joke. Theo doesn't laugh.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Jenna laughing nervously at a dinner table while Theo stares down at his plate, unsmiling. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm dining light. Mood: strained.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm dining light

MOOD

strained

ACTION

Jenna forcing a laugh

142
SHOT**14:57**
5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“They’ve been paying for five years and the bank still owns most of the red door.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The red front door of Theo and Jenna's house with a large bank logo shadow cast over most of it. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium metaphorical shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: ironic ownership.

CAMERA

medium metaphorical shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

ironic ownership

ACTION

the shadow covering the door

143
SHOT**15:03**
5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“At their Fourth of July barbecue, Theo stands at the grill a little too long”

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo standing alone at the grill with a spatula, staring blankly at the smoke. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot on Theo. Lighting: bright summer daylight. Mood: preoccupied.

CAMERA

medium shot on Theo

LIGHTING

bright summer daylight

MOOD

preoccupied

ACTION

staring at the grill

144
SHOT**15:08**
8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“after the burgers are done. He tells you they refinanced. Stretched it back out to thirty years to make the payment work.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of refinance paperwork reading "Term: 30 years" on a patio table. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: bright summer daylight. Mood: resigned.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

bright summer daylight

MOOD

resigned

ACTION

the paper flapping in the breeze

145
SHOT**15:17**
7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“We’ll own it when we’re sixty-two, he says, and flips a burger that doesn’t need flipping. He laughs. You laugh.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo flipping a burger unnecessarily, both men laughing awkwardly. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: bright summer daylight. Mood: forced humor.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

bright summer daylight

MOOD

forced humor

ACTION

flipping the burger

146

SHOT

15:24

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Neither of you means it. Behind him, the backyard is still soft from the last flood.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The soggy, muddy backyard behind Theo with lawn chairs sinking into the soft ground. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: bright summer daylight. Mood: lingering damage.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

bright summer daylight

MOODlingering
damage**ACTION**

chairs sinking slightly

147

SHOT

15:30

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Marcus's rent goes to \$2,900. He gets a letter slid under his door about the renewal.”

IMAGE PROMPT

An envelope slid under a sleek apartment door, Marcus picking it up. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: uneasy.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

uneasy

ACTION

bending to pick it up

148

SHOT

15:36

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He shows it to you on his phone and says, it's fine, it's fine, the way people say it when it isn't.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus showing the protagonist the notice on his phone at a café table. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: forced calm.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

forced calm

ACTION

holding out the phone

149

SHOT

15:44

5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Four years in that building. You do the math in your head without meaning to.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist staring into the distance with small mental math figures floating around his head. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: calculating.

CAMERA

close-up

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

calculating

ACTION

doing math silently

150

SHOT

15:50

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“More than \$110,000 in rent. Every dollar of it paying down a stranger's mortgage.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Rent checks flowing into a stranger landlord's mortgage chute. Character notes: the landlord is a smug middle-aged man in an expensive suit. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical wide shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight, neutral tones. Mood: ironic.

CAMERA

metaphorical wide shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight, neutral tones

MOOD

ironic

ACTION

money flowing away

151

SHOT

15:55

5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He owns the linen shirts. He owns the watch. He doesn't own a single brick.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus in a linen shirt checking his luxury watch. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot on Marcus. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: surface wealth.

CAMERA

medium shot on Marcus

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

surface wealth

ACTION

admiring the watch

152

SHOT

16:00

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And the landlord he's never met just bought a second building. Nobody failed. That's the part that matters.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A smiling landlord in a suit shaking hands over a "SOLD" sign on a second apartment building. Character notes: the landlord is a smug middle-aged man in an expensive suit. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: ironic success.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

ironic success

ACTION

shaking hands

153

SHOT

16:07

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“They just built lives that have to be fed. And the feeding never stops.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Houses, cars and apartments drawn as hungry creatures with open mouths beside the friends. Character notes: the friends are Marcus (tall, fade haircut, linen shirt), Theo (stocky, bearded, flannel), Jenna (auburn ponytail, mustard cardigan) and Priya (dark wavy hair, olive jacket). Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical medium shot. Lighting: soft clean daylight. Mood: draining.

CAMERA

metaphorical medium shot

LIGHTING

soft clean daylight

MOOD

draining

ACTION

the creatures waiting to be fed

154

SHOT

16:12

1.9s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“Yours, quietly, started feeding you.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A small growing money tree beside the protagonist's bed dropping coins into his hand. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal crewneck sweater, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: quiet reward.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
metaphorical medium shot	soft warm daylight	quiet reward	coins falling gently

STAGE 8 OF 11

The Nine Seconds

Age 28 · What the rent money really bought

Shots 155-172 · 18 images

16:14 – 17:58

155
SHOT

16:14

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You're twenty-eight when you read a line on a statement twice. Before a single new deposit,”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist reading a paper statement twice at the kitchen table, eyebrows slightly raised. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: surprised.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

surprised

ACTION

reading closely

156
SHOT

16:20

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“your account grew \$14,000 that year on its own. While you worked. While you slept under the stars.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A statement line reading "Growth this year: +\$14,000" glowing on the page. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: passive reward.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

passive reward

ACTION

the number glowing

157
SHOT

16:27

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“While you sat at the kitchen table listening to your father complain about the neighbor's leaf blower.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His father complaining while pointing out the window at a neighbor with a loud leaf blower. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: humorous, domestic.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOOD

humorous, domestic

ACTION

pointing outside

158
SHOT**16:33**
5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Your salary is still the bigger number. But it isn't the only one working anymore.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A second income stream drawn as a flowing river joining the main river. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical wide shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: compounding.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
metaphorical wide shot	soft warm daylight, gentle shadows	compounding	the rivers merging

159
SHOT**16:38**
7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“That same winter, your father slips on the back steps carrying groceries. A broken hip. Surgery. Eight weeks of recovery.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His father slipping on icy back steps while carrying grocery bags, groceries flying. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: cold winter daylight. Mood: sudden, painful.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide shot	cold winter daylight	sudden, painful	falling backward

160
SHOT**16:46**
5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Your mother can't lift him alone. And you're there. Not because you rearranged your life.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist appearing at the bottom of the stairs, ready to help. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: present, dependable.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft warm daylight, gentle shadows	present, dependable	stepping forward

161
SHOT**16:51**
7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Because you never left it. You hear him fall from upstairs. You're at the bottom of the steps in nine seconds.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in the upstairs bedroom snapping his head toward a loud crash sound. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: alert.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft warm daylight, gentle shadows	alert	turning his head

162
SHOT**16:59**
5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You drive him to the hospital in your repaired car. Every morning for eight weeks,”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist driving the repaired sedan with his father in the passenger seat wincing. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot inside the car. Lighting: cold winter daylight. Mood: urgent, caring.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot inside the car	cold winter daylight	urgent, caring	gripping the wheel

163
SHOT**17:05**
6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“you help him from the bed to the chair before work. Every night, you help him back.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist helping his father from a bed into an armchair in the early morning. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his father is a heavyset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: cool early-morning light. Mood: caring, steady.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium two-shot	cool early-morning light	caring, steady	lifting under his arm

164
SHOT**17:11**
5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The money you didn't spend on rent bought something you didn't know you were buying.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist holding a gift box labeled "PRESENCE" instead of keys to a loft. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium metaphorical shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: unexpected value.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium metaphorical shot	soft warm daylight, gentle shadows	unexpected value	holding the gift

165

SHOT

17:17

5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Being in the house when it mattered. That’s the first time the whole strange arrangement”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist at the window of his childhood bedroom, a soft smile almost appearing. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: quiet realization.

CAMERA

close-up

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

quiet realization

ACTION

looking outside

166

SHOT

17:22

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“feels like it was worth it. Not the balance. The nine seconds. One night during his recovery,”

IMAGE PROMPT

A scale with a bank balance on one side and a stopwatch reading "0:09" on the other, the stopwatch side heavier. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up metaphor. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: meaningful.

CAMERA

close-up metaphor

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

meaningful

ACTION

the stopwatch side tipping down

167

SHOT

17:28

3.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“your mother sits across from you at the kitchen table”

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother sitting down across from the protagonist at the kitchen table. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: intimate.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

intimate

ACTION

sitting down

168

SHOT

17:32

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“with a pencil and the mortgage statement. She doesn’t hide it this time. She slides it over. Look, she says.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother laying a pencil and the mortgage statement openly on the table. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: open, trusting.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

open, trusting

ACTION

placing them down

169

SHOT

17:40

3.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And she taps a number she’s circled. Twenty-two payments left.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of his mother's finger tapping a circled number reading "22 payments left". Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: emotional, proud.

CAMERA

extreme close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOODemotional,
proud**ACTION**

tapping the circle

170

SHOT

17:43

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“It was supposed to be eight more years. She doesn't say thank you. She doesn't have to.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother looking down at the statement, eyes glistening, saying nothing. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on his mother. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: grateful, unspoken.

CAMERA

close-up on his mother

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOODgrateful,
unspoken**ACTION**

eyes lowered

171

SHOT

17:50

5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She just keeps her finger on the number a little longer than she needs to,”

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother's finger resting firmly on the circled number. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: tender.

CAMERA

extreme close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

tender

ACTION

finger pressing down

172

SHOT

17:55

3.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“like it might move if she lets go.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother's finger guarding the number as if holding it in place. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: fragile hope.

CAMERA

extreme close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

fragile hope

ACTION

not letting go

STAGE 9 OF 11

The Cost of Silence

Age 29 · When the secret becomes a wall

Shots 173-193 · 21 images
17:58 – 20:11

173

SHOT

17:58

7.0s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“But something else starts happening too. Something you don't like. Your mother's friends from church ask her about you.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist frowning slightly as a gray storm cloud forms faintly above the house. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: unease.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft warm daylight	unease	frowning

174

SHOT

18:05

3.7s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“You can hear her through the kitchen wall one Sunday.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist in the hallway with his ear near the kitchen wall, listening. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight. Mood: eavesdropping.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	soft warm daylight	eavesdropping	listening

175

SHOT

18:09

4.8s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“He's figuring it out, she says. He's a late bloomer. He'll be fine.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother on the phone in the kitchen, smiling bravely while speaking. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: defensive, loving.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm overhead kitchen light	defensive, loving	talking on the phone

176

SHOT

18:14

3.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Her voice is the one she uses to defend things.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of his mother's determined face mid-sentence. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: tight close-up. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: protective.

CAMERA

tight close-up

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOOD

protective

ACTION

speaking firmly

177

SHOT

18:17

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And she's defending you. Because she doesn't know about the account. Nobody does. You could walk in and end it. One sentence.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother standing like a shield in front of a small silhouette of the protagonist. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical medium shot. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: loyal, unaware.

CAMERA

metaphorical medium shot

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOOD

loyal, unaware

ACTION

holding up a shield

178

SHOT

18:25

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You stand in the hallway with your hand on the wall. Then you go back upstairs.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist standing frozen in the hallway, one hand pressed flat against the wall. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: torn.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

torn

ACTION

standing still

179

SHOT

18:31

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You never chose to lie. You just never corrected anyone. And at some point those became the same thing.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist alone with a small speech bubble crossed out, his mouth shut. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: guilty silence.

CAMERA

close-up

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

guilty silence

ACTION

staying quiet

180

SHOT

18:38

4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Then it gets uglier. Marcus calls one night. He's moving out. Somewhere cheaper.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist on a phone call in his bedroom, Marcus shown in a split panel packing boxes in his apartment. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen medium shots. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: humbling.

CAMERA

split-screen medium shots

LIGHTING

dim evening light

MOOD

humbling

ACTION

Marcus taping a box

181

SHOT

18:43

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He's embarrassed about it, so he makes it about you. Hey, he says, why don't we get a two-bedroom together?”

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus pacing in his half-packed apartment with an embarrassed grin. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot on Marcus. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: embarrassed.

CAMERA

medium shot on Marcus

LIGHTING

dim evening light

MOOD

embarrassed

ACTION

pacing

182

SHOT

18:51

5.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“I can cover the deposit. It'd be good for you. Get you out of there.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus generously offering, holding up a credit card in a thought bubble. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot on Marcus. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: generous, overextended.

CAMERA

medium shot on Marcus

LIGHTING

dim evening light

MOOD

generous, overextended

ACTION

holding up the card

183

SHOT

18:56

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He's being generous. He's being kind. And he's offering to rescue you with money he doesn't have.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Marcus offering a life ring made of crumpled bills, a hole in the ring. Character notes: Marcus is a tall, stylish man in his late twenties with a neat fade haircut, a confident grin and a cream linen shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: ironic.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
metaphorical medium shot	soft warm daylight, gentle shadows	ironic	tossing the ring

184

SHOT

19:02

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You could tell him the truth. You could pay the whole year's rent on a two-bedroom without blinking.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A thought bubble above the protagonist showing him casually paying a full year's rent. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with thought bubble. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: hidden capability.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot with thought bubble	dim evening light	hidden capability	imagining paying

185

SHOT

19:09

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Instead you say, let me think about it. And you let him feel generous.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist on the phone with a neutral expression, saying he'll think about it. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: evasive.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up	dim evening light	evasive	speaking calmly

186

SHOT

19:14

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And when you hang up, you notice you're smiling. That's the part that scares you. You've started to enjoy it. Being underestimated.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist catching his own smiling reflection in a dark window and freezing. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: unsettling.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	dim evening light	unsettling	staring at his reflection

187

SHOT

19:22

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The private math at every table. Knowing what nobody knows. You catch yourself guarding the secret, not because you need to anymore,”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist guarding a small locked chest at the foot of his bed. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: dim evening light. Mood: possessive.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

dim evening light

MOOD

possessive

ACTION

resting a hand on the chest

188

SHOT

19:31

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“but because you like who you get to be inside it. And it lands on you, lying under the stars.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist sitting inside a small glowing secret room, comfortable and alone. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: seductive isolation.

CAMERA

metaphorical medium shot

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

seductive isolation

ACTION

sitting comfortably

189

SHOT

19:38

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“If you need everyone to think you're stuck, their opinion is still running your life. You just flipped the direction.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The marionette strings flipping upside down while still attached. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: metaphorical medium shot. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: ironic.

CAMERA

metaphorical medium shot

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

ironic

ACTION

strings reversing

190

SHOT

19:45

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“For years, you refused to perform success. And somewhere along the way, you started performing failure just as hard.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist wearing a costume labeled "FAILURE" in front of a mirror. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: soft warm daylight, gentle shadows. Mood: ironic performance.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

soft warm daylight, gentle shadows

MOOD

ironic performance

ACTION

adjusting the costume

191

SHOT

19:52

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Priya texts you the next morning. Out of nowhere. You okay? You've seemed far away lately.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist's phone lighting up with a text from Priya on his nightstand at sunrise. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: cool early-morning light. Mood: caring.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

cool early-morning light

MOOD

caring

ACTION

the phone lighting up

192

SHOT

19:58

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You start typing the truth. The rule. The number. Eight years of it. You look at it for a long time.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist typing a long reply on his phone in bed. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up over his hand. Lighting: cool early-morning light. Mood: vulnerable.

CAMERA

close-up over his hand

LIGHTING

cool early-morning light

MOOD

vulnerable

ACTION

typing quickly

193

SHOT

20:06

4.4s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“Then you delete it and send a photo of your mother's meatloaf.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist deleting the message and sending a photo of meatloaf instead. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: cool early-morning light. Mood: deflecting.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	cool early-morning light	deflecting	tapping send

STAGE 10 OF 11

Back on the Rooftop

Age 30 · Paid in full

Shots 194-214 · 21 images
20:11 – 22:24

194

SHOT

20:11

7.8s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“Which brings you back to the rooftop. Marcus's thirtieth. The heated pool. The tablet the waiter never got to hand you.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The waiter walking away with the unused payment tablet. Character notes: the waiter is a young man in a black apron. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: unseen.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	unseen	the waiter walking off

195

SHOT

20:18

4.8s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“Your phone in your pocket, heavy with one line you haven't shown anyone.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the protagonist's hand resting over his jacket pocket with a faintly glowing phone outline. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: heavy secret.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up insert	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	heavy secret	his hand resting

196

SHOT

20:23

7.0s

☐ Image

☐ Animated

☐ Placed

“Here's what it says. A loan servicing notice. Your parents' mortgage. Final payment received. Balance: \$0.00. Paid in full.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone screen reading "Final payment received. Balance: \$0.00. PAID IN FULL" with a green check mark. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: triumphant.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
extreme close-up insert	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	triumphant	the check mark glowing

197

SHOT

20:30

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Eight years of \$800 envelopes on the kitchen table. Every one of them sent to the principal.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A stack of eight years' worth of "\$800" envelopes on a kitchen table. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up metaphor. Lighting: warm overhead kitchen light. Mood: devoted.

CAMERA

close-up metaphor

LIGHTING

warm overhead kitchen light

MOOD

devoted

ACTION

envelopes stacked high

198

SHOT

20:37

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Eleven years of payments finished in eight. The house you've been laughed at for living in”

IMAGE PROMPT

The modest family house at dusk with laughter speech bubbles floating around it. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: warm dusk light. Mood: vindicated.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

warm dusk light

MOOD

vindicated

ACTION

the house standing

199

SHOT

20:42

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“doesn't belong to the bank anymore. It belongs to the two people who left the porch light on.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother and father on the porch under the warm porch light, smiling softly. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan; his father is a heavysset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm porch light against cool dusk. Mood: deserved peace.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm porch light against cool dusk

MOOD

deserved peace

ACTION

sitting together

200

SHOT

20:49

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You've been paying a mortgage this whole time. Just not someone else's. The party thins out after midnight.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist at the rooftop railing with a calm, quiet smile. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: vindicated.

CAMERA

close-up

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

vindicated

ACTION

looking out at the city

201

SHOT

20:56

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Theo and Jenna leave first, because their dog has been alone since six. Marcus disappears into a group of coworkers.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Theo and Jenna waving goodbye as they head for the elevator. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt; Jenna is a warm woman with a long auburn ponytail and a mustard cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: tired, warm.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

tired, warm

ACTION

waving

202

SHOT

21:03

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And then it's just you and Priya at the railing, the city spread out below like a circuit board.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist and Priya standing alone at the rooftop railing. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: intimate.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

intimate

ACTION

leaning on the railing

203

SHOT

21:10

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She doesn't look at you. She just says it. So when are you actually moving out?”

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya looking out at the city, not at the protagonist, speaking quietly. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: candid.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

candid

ACTION

speaking

204

SHOT

21:16

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The same question. Eight years later. On a different roof. For eight years, this is where you've said soon.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A faded inset of Theo asking the same question at the old party eight years ago. Character notes: Theo is a stocky bearded man with tired eyes in a flannel shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split-screen medium shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: full circle.

CAMERA

split-screen medium
shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the
blue glow of a heated pool against
a cool night city skyline

MOOD

full circle

ACTION

both moments side by
side

205

SHOT

21:23

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“This time you take out your phone. You open the account. Not the mortgage. The other one.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist taking out his phone and opening an investment app. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: decisive.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the
blue glow of a heated pool against
a cool night city skyline

MOOD

decisive

ACTION

opening the app

206

SHOT

21:30

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And you set it face up on the railing between you. \$214,000.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Phone screen showing "\$214,000" in large digits on the rooftop railing. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up insert. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: stunning reveal.

CAMERA

extreme close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the
blue glow of a heated pool against
a cool night city skyline

MOOD

stunning reveal

ACTION

the number glowing

207
SHOT**21:34**
7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Priya looks at it for a long time. She doesn't say wow. She doesn't ask how. She just goes quiet,”

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya staring at the phone with wide eyes, saying nothing. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on Priya. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: stunned.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
close-up on Priya	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	stunned	staring

208
SHOT**21:41**
6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“the way you do when a story you thought you knew turns out to be a different story.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist and Priya silhouetted at the railing against the glittering city. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: reframing.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
wide shot	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	reframing	silent together

209
SHOT**21:48**
5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“How long? she finally asks. Since the driveway, you say. Since the four boxes.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A faded flashback inset of the driveway and four cardboard boxes beside the protagonist. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot with flashback overlay. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: origin.

CAMERA	LIGHTING	MOOD	ACTION
medium shot with flashback overlay	warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline	origin	remembering

210

SHOT

21:53

8.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She asks if your parents know. You tell her about the mortgage. About the envelopes. About your mother’s finger on the number.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya asking about his parents while the protagonist shows the mortgage notice. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket; his parents are a small graying woman in a faded maroon cardigan and a heavyset gray-mustached man in a plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: deepening.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

deepening

ACTION

showing the notice

211

SHOT

22:01

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Priya turns back to the city and doesn't say anything for a while. Then she says,”

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya turning back toward the city, quiet, the night wind lifting her hair. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: moved.

CAMERA

medium shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

moved

ACTION

looking out

212

SHOT

22:07

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“that's the most grown-up thing anyone on this roof has done. She laughs once, softly, not at you.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Priya looking at the protagonist with deep respect. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: admiring.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

admiring

ACTION

speaking softly

213

SHOT

22:14

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“We all thought you were stuck, she says. And you give her the only true thing you have left.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist looking at Priya with a vulnerable, open expression. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: Priya is a calm, observant woman with dark wavy shoulder-length hair, small gold hoop earrings and an olive jacket. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: honest.

CAMERA

close-up

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

honest

ACTION

meeting her eyes

214

SHOT

22:21

2.6s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“For a while, you say. I was.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist answering with a faint, real smile at the railing. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up. Lighting: warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline. Mood: humble truth.

CAMERA

close-up

LIGHTING

warm golden string lights and the blue glow of a heated pool against a cool night city skyline

MOOD

humble truth

ACTION

speaking quietly

STAGE 11 OF 11

Moving Out

After · The last star

Shots 215–231 · 17 images

22:24 – 24:06

215
SHOT22:24
4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Three weeks later, you sign for a small house on the east side.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A cozy brick two-family house on a tree-lined street with a "SOLD" sign. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: wide shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: accomplished.

CAMERA

wide shot

LIGHTING

warm natural light with amber accents

MOOD

accomplished

ACTION

the sign in the yard

216
SHOT22:28
4.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“A two-family. You'll live in one half. The other half pays for itself.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Split view of the two-family house, the protagonist on one side and a tenant family moving in on the other. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: cutaway medium shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: smart, stable.

CAMERA

cutaway medium shot

LIGHTING

warm natural light with amber accents

MOOD

smart, stable

ACTION

both halves lived in

217
SHOT22:33
6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“You put down forty percent. The loan officer reads your file twice, then looks up at you”

IMAGE PROMPT

A loan office with a middle-aged loan officer reading a thick file across a desk from the protagonist. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: the loan officer is a middle-aged man in a navy suit and striped tie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: professional.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm natural light with amber accents

MOOD

professional

ACTION

reading the file

218

SHOT

22:39

4.1s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“with a different face than the one he walked in with.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The loan officer's expression shifting to respect, eyebrows raised. Character notes: the loan officer is a middle-aged man in a navy suit and striped tie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up on the loan officer. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: newfound respect.

CAMERA

close-up on the loan officer

LIGHTING

warm natural light with amber accents

MOOD

newfound respect

ACTION

adjusting his tie

219

SHOT

22:44

7.0s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He'd seen the address on your application. Your parents' address. He'd assumed. Now he asks if you'd like coffee.”

IMAGE PROMPT

Close-up of the loan application with the parents' home address highlighted. Character notes: his parents are a small graying woman in a faded maroon cardigan and a heavysset gray-mustached man in a plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: assumption.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm natural light with amber accents

MOOD

assumption

ACTION

the address highlighted

220

SHOT

22:51

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He walks you to the elevator himself. He tells you to call his cell, not the office line.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The loan officer handing over a business card with a handwritten cell number. Character notes: the loan officer is a middle-aged man in a navy suit and striped tie. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: exclusive.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm natural light with amber accents

MOOD

exclusive

ACTION

handing the card

221

SHOT

22:57

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Your last night at home, you stand on your old bed and peel the stars off the ceiling.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist standing on his twin bed reaching up to peel the plastic stars off the ceiling. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: low-angle shot. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: nostalgic farewell.

CAMERA

low-angle shot

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars

MOOD

nostalgic farewell

ACTION

peeling a star

222

SHOT

23:04

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“One by one. Thirty of them come off clean. One won't let go. You leave it there.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A handful of peeled stars in his palm, one remaining stuck on the ceiling. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: tender.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with
the faint green glow of plastic
ceiling stars

MOOD

tender

ACTION

the last star clinging

223

SHOT

23:10

6.3s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Downstairs, your mother is at the kitchen table, holding the spare key on the faded blue lanyard.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother holding the spare key on the faded blue lanyard in her hands. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: nostalgic.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

nostalgic

ACTION

holding the key

224

SHOT

23:17

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“She tries to give it back to you. You close her hand around it.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His mother holding the key out toward the protagonist. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: letting go.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

letting go

ACTION

offering the key

225

SHOT

23:22

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Keep it, you tell her. I'll need it. On the porch, your father is sitting in the chair”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist smiling softly at his mother across the kitchen table. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his mother is a small woman in her late fifties with short graying hair, reading glasses on a beaded chain and a faded maroon cardigan. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: dim warm lamp light. Mood: loving.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

dim warm lamp light

MOOD

loving

ACTION

speaking gently

226

SHOT

23:28

5.9s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“he couldn't get out of on his own a year ago. He stands up without help.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A faded inset of his father struggling to stand during his hip recovery. Character notes: his father is a heavysset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: split medium shot. Lighting: warm porch light against cool night. Mood: contrast.

CAMERA

split medium shot

LIGHTING

warm porch light against cool night

MOOD

contrast

ACTION

struggling to rise

227

SHOT

23:34

4.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He shakes your hand like you're someone he just met and likes.”

IMAGE PROMPT

His father shaking the protagonist's hand warmly on the porch. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Character notes: his father is a heavysset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium two-shot. Lighting: warm porch light against cool night. Mood: respect.

CAMERA

medium two-shot

LIGHTING

warm porch light against cool night

MOOD

respect

ACTION

shaking hands

228

SHOT

23:39

7.8s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“Then the porch light comes on behind him. Same as every night. Nobody touched the switch. It's on a timer now.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The porch light clicking on above his father's head. Character notes: his father is a heavysset man in his sixties with a gray mustache and a worn plaid shirt. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: low-angle medium shot. Lighting: warm porch light against cool night. Mood: constant.

CAMERA

low-angle medium shot

LIGHTING

warm porch light against cool night

MOOD

constant

ACTION

the light coming on

229

SHOT

23:47

7.4s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“He set it the week you moved home. It started with a number on a rental app. \$1,700 a month.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A phone rental app screen showing "\$1,700/mo" fading into the night sky. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: close-up insert. Lighting: warm natural light with amber accents. Mood: origin.

CAMERA

close-up insert

LIGHTING

warm natural light with amber accents

MOOD

origin

ACTION

the number fading

230

SHOT

23:54

6.7s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“The money changed what you were free to choose. The silence changed what you were willing to say.”

IMAGE PROMPT

The protagonist walking toward his new two-family house with a box under his arm. The protagonist is a young man with an oversized round head, short dark-brown side-parted hair, thin rectangular glasses, large half-lidded unimpressed eyes and a small flat mouth, always deadpan, wearing a charcoal quarter-zip pullover, and is the darkest value in the frame. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: medium-wide shot. Lighting: warm dusk light. Mood: freedom.

CAMERA

medium-wide shot

LIGHTING

warm dusk light

MOOD

freedom

ACTION

walking up the path

231

SHOT

24:01

5.2s

- ☐ Image
☐ Animated
☐ Placed

“And the house you were laughed at for living in was never someone else's.”

IMAGE PROMPT

A final close-up of the single plastic star still glowing on the empty bedroom ceiling. Style: flat 2D cartoon webcomic illustration, bold clean black outlines, flat cel shading, desaturated slate-blue and gray palette with muted olive, rust, mustard and maroon accents, detailed lived-in background, semi-chibi characters with oversized heads, layered foreground, mid-ground and background, 16:9 frame with the bottom 15% kept clear of important detail. Camera: extreme close-up. Lighting: dim warm bedside lamp light with the faint green glow of plastic ceiling stars. Mood: final, tender.

CAMERA

extreme close-up

LIGHTING

dim warm bedside lamp light with
the faint green glow of plastic
ceiling stars

MOOD

final, tender

ACTION

the star glowing